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OTHERS FORMS OF DWELLING: A DALIT – FEMINIST PERSPECTIVE

Abstract

This paper is an attempt to bring together different values from different socio-cultural contexts together with an intention to weave a meaningful narrative. For this reason, this paper will focus on the 'Indigenous Values' as explained by Philip Arnold in his book *The Urgency of Indigenous Values* as a basic structural framework to think about the Dalit women of the Indian subcontinent in consonance with these values and urgency. Similar to the indigenous values are the values lived and experienced by these Dalit women who help us to explore the different frameworks of existing in this shared world. To be precise, this paper is an earnest attempt to talk about the other ways of being in the world through the urgency of Dalit values. It is in this sense that this paper attempts to bring forth a shared framework to work with. This is a secondary scholarship based on the ethnography of other renowned scholars like Philip P Arnold and Lucinda Ramberg.

Keywords*: Jogatis, Dalit religion, Yellamma, ritual, kinship, state, marriage, heterotopias*

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Introduction

In his ground-breaking book, Philip Arnold, a Historian of Religions, sheds light on the challenges of abandoning the category of religion while simultaneously utilizing it to explore "Other" values. This resonates deeply with me as I endeavour to apply my training as a Scholar of Religions in Graduate school to critically engage with the religions of marginalized groups in my own country, particularly Dalit women.[2] It is fascinating to observe how the category of religion has been systematically employed to undermine the values of these communities within their socio-cultural contexts. Consequently, using terms such as "Indigenous religions" or "Dalit Religions" proves to be inadequate. This is why we advocate for a shift towards emphasizing 'values' over religion.[3]

Philip P Arnold's compelling argument highlights the destructive role of religion in severing the sacred bond between Indigenous peoples and their environment, perpetuated by the settler-colonial race.[4] This sheds light on the power dynamics at play between those who adhere to organized religions and those whose beliefs are less structured. A similar power dynamic exists for the Dalit community in India, who find themselves at the lowest rung of the Varna[5] hierarchy due to the circumstances of their birth. Their sole purpose in society is to serve the higher varnas, namely the Brahmans (the priestly class), the Ksatriyas (the warrior class), and the Vaisyas (the merchant class), if they aspire to attain salvation and liberation in this world. Adding to their plight, they were prohibited from reading or even hearing the Vedas, the religious scriptures of ancient India, as dictated by prescriptive yet orthodox texts like the Manusmriti/Manava-Dharma shastra, authored by Manu around the 2nd century BCE.[6] Furthermore, women have consistently been portrayed as the "Other" and deemed inferior in society, subjecting Dalit women to a twofold subjugation and oppression based on both their birth and gender.

Dalit women occupy a unique position at the crossroads of caste and gender in the history of Modern India, as highlighted by Shailaja Paik. Despite their significant contributions in creating new knowledge, consciousness, and praxis from the grassroots level, their role in India studies and South Asian Feminism has often been overlooked. This oversight can be attributed to the lack of widespread epistemological shifts necessary to analyze the lives of Dalit women and the feminist consciousness they have cultivated. However, scholars like Paik intervene by examining Dalit feminism as a womanist-humanist complex, which paves the way for inclusive, democratic, and productive politics. By embracing this

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[2] Dalit- literally means oppressed or broken ones. It is a Marathi word, popularized by Dr. B.R.Ambedkar , the Dalit leader who also chaired the Drafting Committee of Indian Constitution.

[3] Philip P. Arnold, The Urgency of the Indigenous Values (Syracuse University Press, 2023).

[4] Arnold, Urgency of the Indigenous Values

[5] Varna order is the oldest system of a social hierarchy existing in Indian society since Vedic times circa 1500-500 BCE. It divided the society into 4 rigid categories as mentioned above. This also led to the discrimination against those at the lowest position in society.

[6] Manava-Dharmashastra also known as Manusmriti is one of the oldest and prejudiced religious treatises which was authored by someone called Manu. It is a text on Dharma or duties which should be the guiding force behind every action in the Hindu world order. It is rigorous and discriminatory in nature, which is valued by the upper caste groups even in Contemporary India and abroad.

perspective, we can recognize the fluidity of womanhood, develop new theoretical frameworks, and decode systemic power structures to foster meaningful change.

For Paik, the Dalit womanist-humanist complex is deeply rooted in lived experiences and the concepts and theories that emerge from them. This approach enables a profound analysis of the broader struggle for a comprehensive understanding of the diverse worlds inhabited by the most marginalized Dalit women.[7] It is within this context that the essence of this paper lies, as it aims to critically engage with the lived realities of Dalit women in Southern India through an ethnographic exploration of the institution of Jogatis or Devadasis, who are married to the deity Devi Yellamma in northern Karnataka, as documented by Lucinda Ramberg.

The Jogatis and the Institution of Devadasis in Northern Karnataka

Ramberg argues that if one is to make sense of the experiences of Jogatis, it is important to ask who or what are Jogatis. These South Indian women are given or dedicated to Yellamma (their goddess) as children by their parents, meaning that they are married to the devi Yellamma and do not marry men in their lifetime.[8] Dedication becomes their main rite and they become the pujaris or priests of the devi. These Dalit women transact the favour of goddess outside the main walls of her temple and sex outside the bounds of conjugal matrimony. Their alliance with the goddess is not recognized as legitimate religion or kinship within the law and within the perception of the state (Ramberg 2014, 3).[9]

Moreover, all those dedicated to Yellamma wrap themselves in Sari and embody the devi or the goddess. This is to say that whether the dedicated were recognized as boys sexed male or girls sexed female as children, they become women and are called Jogatis, although male women are commonly referred to as Jogappas (Ramberg 2014).[10] It is important to take a moment here to assess the involvement of men in this institution. It becomes clearly evident that even male Dalit children were being dedicated to the Goddess and then being accepted as women and hence they constitute a group of male-women who come to embody the Devi itself. It reflects the fact that this institution was open to not only women but other genders as well, as long as one was dedicated to serve the Yellamma. This in turn takes us back to Foucault's idea of heterotopias of deviation where individuals whose behaviour is deviant in relation to the required mean or norm are placed, such as prisons or psychiatric hospitals.[11] This is so because these Dalit males, after being dedicated to Yellamma, become female in order to gain a new identity which in turn allows them to exist in a new framework in this world which is besides the normative ways of existence laid out for the men in the Indian society. This marks a clear case of heterotopia of deviation with respect to the Jogappas.

Moreover, these Jogatis also call themselves and are also called by others, as devadasis. This is a term used all over India, which is translated as servant or slave or dasi of the God. Dedication becomes their central rite of initiation and they become pujaris or priests of Yellamma. Also, very interestingly, these Dalit women transact the favour of the Goddess outside the main walls of the temple and sex outside the bounds of conjugal matrimony. They who are promised to the devi can never marry any other, so they take up the upper

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[7] Shailaja Paik, "Dalit Feminist Thought," in Routledge Handbook of Gender in South Asia, ed. Leela Fernandes (Routledge, 2021), 55–69.

[8] Lucinda Ramberg, Given to the Goddess: South Indian Devadasis and the Sexuality of Religion (Duke University Press, 2014), 3.

[9] Ramberg, Given to the Goddess, 3

[10] Ibid.

[11] Michel Foucault, "Of Other Spaces: Utopias and Heterotopias," trans. Jay Miskowiec, Architecture/Mouvement/Continuité (October 1984): 5, https://web.mit.edu/allanmc/www/foucault1.pdf.

caste wealthy men as their patrons and enter into an illicit sexual relationship which lies outside the sanctity of bond created by marriage. It is therefore that Jogatis are mostly defined exclusively by their illicit sexuality.

It is in this background that both their religion and their kinship is not recognized either by state or the laws of the state. In fact, the mainstream media, and the feminist social reformers see these practices and institutions as degraded positions of outcaste women who dedicate their lives to a superstitious ritual enactments and sexual exploitation. However, this is too simplistic picture of this whole institution which is both flawed as it does not talk about this institution through the lens of those Dalit women who become Jogatis and devadasis. It is important to talk about their experiences of being and embodying a Jogati in this world, who sees them as nothing but prostitutes. It is here that Ramberg uses her ethnographic account to make a positive interventionist move in this narrative to uncover who are Jogatis by closely working with them.

The Question of 'Religion'

Arnold in his book also argue that the long history of conflicts and aggressive interpretive moves by scholars of religion have wreaked havoc upon the people to whom the category has been applied and this why some categories like "Indigenous Religions" do not seem viable categories to do justice to the questions of religions for some communities like the Indigenous peoples for him and the Dalit women for my case. It is also important to ask what counts as religion or what constitutes a religion particularly because it is a question of several complexities intertwined together which involve the politics of knowledge as well as power dynamics in the form of status of beliefs and practices. Ramberg argues that as far as the rituals surrounding Yellamma are concerned, "popular religion" is cast as an obstacle to social progress. It is a superstition and the kind of false belief that secular government institutions and civil society must work against in order to pursue the "social good". Also, the religiosity of the Devadasi is now consigned to the past, they have become degenerated prostitutes, kept women or even beggars. This narrative of decline and the distinction between true and false religion are both standard features of religion as a modern form. Within this framework, the religion of these women, if they can be said to have religion at all, is both the origin and a sign of their fallen condition. It cannot be knowledge and is a superstition, it is an incorrect apprehension of the world leading to a mistaken way of being in the world.[12]

This is a very telling statement shedding light upon the dissonance between the norms of existing in the world versus the defiant forms of dwellings in this world or even their own world making. Ramberg cites another Dalit scholar Y Chinna Rao to argue that Dalits have had their own religious system in which the goddess appeared to be the dominant divine figure, before the advent of Christianity in India. These local goddesses like Mariamma, Poleramma, Peddamma, or any other local deity had nothing in common with the goddesses of the Hindu pantheon. Other than these goddesses, these peoples also worshiped their Kuladevta or caste deity and Inti devata or family deity. It was later than these traditions were assimilated Brahmanical anthropologists and sociologists as 'little' traditions to portray a picture of Hinduism as a great tradition.[13] It is important for us to note the fact that the Dalits never considered themselves as 'Hindu' and had rituals, rites, customs, beliefs, practices etc. of their own before the advent of the British colonizers. And it is after their advent that the practices and rites of the Dalits were colonized as a result of discursive effect of modern anthropological and nationalist conceptions of Hinduism bifurcated between high textual and philosophical Brahmanical religion and low

[12] Ramberg, Given to the Goddess.

[13] Ibid.

vernacular practices. It is in this background that the questions on the status of religiosity of dedicated women is the result of historical configurations of power and knowledge between imperial Britain and occupied India; between nationalist elites and vernacular folks, Brahmans and Dalits, men and women.[14] This again points our attention towards the need for a standardization of religion in the name of nationality and progress for the state of Modern India.

In a similar vein, Eve Rebecca Parker, another scholar working on the Dalit Devadasi women in Southern India, argues that Dalit religions have existed on the margins of Indian society throughout history, yet in contrast to Hindu deities there are no written narratives for the Dalit goddess religions. Instead of being written down, myths and traditions are passed down through spoken word, and as time goes on, it seems that the beliefs of the upper caste have become intertwined with the beliefs of the lower caste, thus changing the way worship is done, and taking away the independence of lower caste religious practices. The 19th Century Christian missionary Henry Whitehead mentions the religious practices of the Mādiga communities in rural India, where they worshiped female deities in temple establishments overseen by Priestesses. The temples had male attendants, who are supposed to protect the shrine and follow the commands of the goddess, but they have a clearly subordinate and servile position. During this time, the Mathammas were not seen as sex workers in the village, but instead they held respected religious positions within their communities. The caste implications point out that all castes feared the goddess Mathamma and contributed to her worship, but caste distinctions prevented anyone other than Mādigas from actively participating in the ceremonies. This is why many scholars argue that the autonomous women dedicated to the supposedly liberating goddess see a different religious principle at work, one that recognizes the mysterious powers of the lower caste woman, the dangerous and benevolent power she brings to the village community. This is Revealing of a religious practice of liberation for the oppressed Dalits.[15]

This analysis sits very well with Ramberg's argument focussing on the world making process of these marginalised women where these women have no such confusion regarding their own status. In fact, in their world, who they are in relation to the devi and her devotees is self- evident and unproblematic. And at the same time, they are also well aware of the state's position on their dedication but yet they stand firm and speak from a different place, a different world. This world centres itself around the devi rather than the state or it could even stand against the state. This is a world which exists beside that world, which is governed by the states, re-enforcing the Christian imperial and Brahmanical Hindu and secular liberal appraisals; this world is produced by the ways of knowing that exceed all such normative structural frameworks. For the dedicated Dalit women, this is the real world, and they are the real pujaris or the priests, whose existence is governed by the presence of Yellamma- they eat from her, wear from her and that is why their relationship to the Goddess is actual and real for them. Their everyday rituals, performative works, their movement across the land, their embodiment of these rituals, all constitute a sensemaking of this world where the devadasis are in an ethical relationship to the goddess (Ramberg 2014).[16] It is therefore that these dedicated women do not see their religion to be false or superstitious, they refuse to believe in reform or the reformer because it is constituted outside their faith and devotion and hence has no claim and meaning for them. Their world is a religious world which is basically counter -culture shaped by a divine feminine who challenges the normative social constructions.

[14] Ibid.

[15] Eve R. Parker, Theologising the Sacred Prostitutes of India: Towards an Indecent Dalit Theology (Brill, 2021).

[16] Ramberg, Given to the Goddess.

Concluding Thoughts

This paper has been an attempt to highlight the urgency of Dalit values and their way of life, drawing inspiration from Philip Arnold's work, "The Urgency of Indigenous Values." It is important to note that the contexts of these narratives are vastly different. While Indigenous values are situated within the Western settler colonial paradigm, the Dalit experience comes from a marginalized community in a Third World country in the East. The intention here is not to transplant concepts from one context to another, but rather to learn from the Indigenous model and apply their values to better understand and articulate the values of marginalized and homogenized communities in India.

As Arnold eloquently argues in his book, the most meaningful dimensions of human life are Indigenous, characterized by a unified system of values rather than religion itself. This Indigenous dimension, or Indigeneity, helps us clarify the contrasting value systems between different categories such as Indigenous and global traditions, Dalit and Hindu traditions, which stem from radically different orientations towards the earth.[17] These values serve as a critical lens to engage with the Devadasi institution, where dedicated Dalit women, much like Indigenous peoples, exist in complete harmony with their environment. Both Indigenous communities and these Dalit women share a religious value that occupies a tangible space and facilitates a genuine connection between the divine and its people in this world. Therefore, the framework of Indigeneity proves invaluable in understanding diverse ways of dwelling in this world, including the experiences of Jogati women in the Dalit communities of Karnataka, India.

[17] Arnold, The Urgency of Indigenous Values